

What the Mirror Knows

She had painted two hundred and thirty portraits. She had never been the subject of one. Now she was, and the painter was her student.

CEFR Level B2

Book 7 of 10 • Psychological Drama / Art • Adult Graded Reader Series

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About This Book

Setting: An art school in London. A studio. A mirror. A portrait in progress.

Genre: Psychological Drama / Art

Characters

- Frances — 61. Portrait painter. Professor of fine art. Twenty-three years at the school.
- Leon — 27. Her student in his final year. Exceptionally talented. Difficult to read.
- The portrait — painted over eight weeks. What it shows and what it knows.
- Power — present throughout, not always where it appears to be.

WHAT THE MIRROR KNOWS

Page 1 — The Request

Leon had asked her at the end of a tutorial in November, in the tone he used for questions he had already decided were reasonable.

He was doing his final-year project on the ethics of portraiture — the question of who had the right to represent whom, and under what conditions, and what the subject owed the artist and the artist owed the subject.

He wanted, he said, to paint a portrait as part of the project — not just analyse one. He wanted his subject to be someone who painted portraits professionally, so that the sitter's understanding of the process would be part of the material.

He wanted to paint her.

Frances had said she would think about it.

She had known, before he finished speaking, that she would say yes.

Vocabulary Support

ethics of portraiture	portre etiği
tutorial	öğrenci danışma dersi
represent	temsil etmek

sitter	portre modeli
material	malzeme, konu
reasonable	makul

She knew before he finished that she would say yes. She said she would think about it.

Page 2 — Why She Said Yes

She had said yes for several reasons, not all of which she had been entirely honest with herself about.

The honest reason was that she was curious — she had painted many people and had, in the course of doing so, developed strong views about the experience of being painted, most of which were based on inference rather than experience.

The less fully acknowledged reason was that she thought Leon was going to be extraordinary — was, in certain respects, already extraordinary — and she wanted to see what an extraordinary portraitist made of her.

The reason she had not acknowledged at all, at first, was that she was sixty-one and she wanted to know what she looked like to someone who was not managing her feelings about it.

Vocabulary Support

inference	çıkarım
acknowledged	kabul etti
extraordinary	olağanüstü
portraitist	portre ressamı
managing feelings	duyguları yönetmek
several reasons	çeşitli nedenler

She wanted to know what she looked like to someone not managing her feelings about it.

Page 3 — The First Session

The first session was a week after the request.

Leon had set up his studio space with the particular organisation of someone who had been thinking about a problem for longer than his apparent preparations suggested.

He had not said much in the first hour — he drew rather than painting in the early sessions, working quickly through a series of position studies before committing to an angle.

Frances sat in the chair he had placed for her and found, with some surprise, that sitting for a portrait was considerably more demanding than she had anticipated.

She had always told her own sitters to be present, not to perform.

It was, she discovered in the first hour, significantly harder than it sounded.

Vocabulary Support

position studies	pozisyon çalışmaları
committing to	... e bağlanmak
considerably more demanding	önemli ölçüde daha zorlu
present, not perform	hazır olmak, performans sergilememek

organisation	organizasyon
preparations	hazırlıklar

Be present, not perform. She had said this for twenty years. In the first hour, she found it hard.

Page 4 — What Leon Did

Leon did not talk much during the sessions.

This was, she had gathered from his other students, characteristic — he was not silent from shyness or lack of engagement but from a form of concentration that apparently required the suppression of most verbal activity.

What he did, in the silences, was look at her with the quality of attention that she recognised from the better students she had taught: the attention that was trying to understand rather than record, that was patient with the object because it knew that the object would eventually yield something the initial looking could not access.

She had told students this for years.

It was, she found, disconcerting to be its object.

Vocabulary Support

suppression	baskılama
disconcerting	rahatsız edici
verbal activity	sözel faaliyet
yield	vermek, sunmak
patient with	... e karşı sabırlı
characteristic	karakteristik

She had described this quality of looking for years. Being its object was disconcerting.

Page 5 — The Mid-Point

At the mid-point of the project — the fourth session — Leon showed her what he had done so far.

He had not offered to show her earlier, and she had not asked, which was a restraint she was proud of, it being considerably harder not to ask than to ask.

The painting was unfinished, of course. But it was also, immediately and unmistakably, her.

This was not, she told herself, what was interesting about it. What was interesting was that it was also, in some way she could not immediately articulate, not quite her.

It was a version of her — a considered, specific version — that the mirror did not show her.

She stood looking at it for some time.

'What do you see?' Leon asked.

'Someone I know fairly well,' she said. 'And don't quite recognise.'

Vocabulary Support

unmistakably	açıkça, şüphesizce
restraint	kendine hâkim olma
articulate	dile getirmek
considered version	düşünülmüş sürüm
mid-point	orta nokta

proud of

... ile gurur duyma

"Someone I know fairly well and don't quite recognise." He has seen something the mirror does not show.

Page 6 — The Difference

She had spent the evening of the fourth session trying to identify what the difference was.

She used the mirror for this, which she recognised as a kind of irony.

What she arrived at, eventually, was this: the painting showed her at a slight temporal remove — not younger or older, but as though the observer had access to information accumulated across time rather than gathered in a single glance.

The mirror showed you as you were at the moment of looking. The painting showed you as you had been, were, and perhaps would be, collapsed into a single image.

She had painted this quality into other people for twenty-three years.

She had not, she thought, known what it felt like to receive it.

It felt like being known rather than seen.

Vocabulary Support

temporal remove	zamansal uzaklık
accumulated	birikmiş
collapsed into	tek bir görüntüye indirgenmiş
single glance	tek bakış

receive it	almak
known rather than seen	görölmek yerine bilinmek

"Being known rather than seen." Twenty-three years of doing this to others. Now she receives it.

Page 7 — The Tutorial Reversed

In the fifth session, she had asked him a question that was technically out of order — tutors did not interrogate students about their process in ways that might imply the tutor had a personal stake in the outcome.

She asked anyway.

'What are you looking for when you look at me?'

Leon was quiet for a moment. He said: 'I'm looking for the person who was thinking before they knew someone was watching.'

She looked at him.

'That's impossible,' she said. 'The subject always knows they're being watched.'

'I know,' he said. 'But there are moments when people forget. I'm waiting for those moments.'

She thought: I have waited for those moments in other people for twenty-three years.

She thought: I did not know anyone had been waiting for them in me.

Vocabulary Support

technically out of order	teknik olarak yersiz
interrogate	sorgulamak

stake in the outcome	sonuca çıkarı bağılı olmak
imply	ima etmek
waiting for	... için beklemek
moments when people forget	insanların unuttuğu anlar

"Waiting for the moments when people forget." She had done this for twenty-three years. He is doing it to her.

Page 8 — Power

She had thought, before the project began, that the power dynamic of the situation was clear: she was the teacher, he was the student.

She had also thought, secondarily, that within the studio, the power would shift: she was the sitter, he was the artist.

What she had not anticipated was that neither of these arrangements adequately described what was actually happening.

The situation was, she was increasingly convinced, not one in which power flowed in either direction simply.

She was his teacher, which meant something. He was painting her, which meant something else. She had more years and more knowledge. He had more access to what she was in this moment than she did.

She was not sure she had a framework adequate to this.

Vocabulary Support

power dynamic	güç dinamiği
shift	kayma
adequately described	yeterince tanımlamak
framework	çerçeve

increasingly convinced	giderek ikna olmuş
secondarily	ikincil olarak

She had no adequate framework for what was happening. The power did not flow simply in either direction.

Page 9 — What the Painting Showed

She saw the nearly completed painting in the seventh session.

It showed a woman in her early sixties sitting in a chair, hands in her lap, looking slightly to the left of the observer.

The woman in the painting had the expression of someone in the act of assessing — not being assessed, not being caught unaware, but actively processing something.

Frances had seen this expression in her own students.

She had not known she wore it.

She thought: he has shown me something I do habitually that I was not conscious of.

She thought: this is what portraits do at their best.

She thought: he is better than I gave him credit for.

She thought: that is one of the things this process has been for.

Vocabulary Support

in the act of	... yaparken
assessing	değerlendiriyor
habitually	alışkanlıkla

conscious of	farkında
gave him credit for	ona güvendiğim
caught unaware	habersiz yakalanmak

He showed her something she does habitually but was not conscious of. That is what portraits do at their best.

Page 10 — The Thesis

Leon's written thesis, which she read in draft before the final submission, was — she had to acknowledge, with the care she always brought to the distinction between a student being good and being what she considered excellent — excellent.

It argued that the ethics of portraiture could not be resolved at the level of consent alone — that consent was necessary but insufficient, because the relationship between sitter and painter was not a static transaction but a dynamic process in which both parties were changed by the encounter.

It argued that what a portrait showed was never the sitter as they were, but the sitter as the painter understood them, which was itself a product of what the sitter allowed the painter to see.

It concluded that the ethics of portraiture required ongoing negotiation, not a single agreement at the start.

Vocabulary Support

ethics	etik
consent	rıza
static transaction	statik işlem
dynamic process	dinamik süreç
ongoing negotiation	süregelen müzakere

insufficient	yetersiz
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Consent necessary but insufficient. The ethics require ongoing negotiation. She agrees with this entirely.

Page 11 — The Question in the Thesis

The thesis contained, in its final chapter, a question that Frances had not been able to stop thinking about since she read it.

Leon had written: The portrait I have made for this project required my subject to be simultaneously the expert and the subject — to bring to the sittings her professional knowledge of what I was doing while experiencing what that doing felt like from the inside. I am not sure that this combination of knowledge and experience is available to sitters who are not practitioners of the form. And I am not sure, having made this portrait, whether any portrait of a sitter who does not understand what portraiture does to people can be fully ethical.

She had read this paragraph three times.

She had thought: he is asking a question I cannot answer.

She had thought: that is what good students do.

Vocabulary Support

simultaneously	eş zamanlı olarak
practitioner of the form	formun uygulayıcısı
fully ethical	tam olarak etik

combination of knowledge and experience	bilgi ve deneyimin birleşimi
available to	... için mevcut
what portraiture does	portrenin ne yaptığı
<i>Can a portrait of someone who does not understand what portraiture does be fully ethical? She cannot answer.</i>	

Page 12 — The Final Session

The final session was the one in which the painting was completed.

Leon did not say it was complete. He simply stopped working, stepped back, and looked at it for a long time.

Frances watched him.

She had seen students recognise the moment of completion before — it was one of the more reliable indicators of whether they would go on to do serious work. The students who couldn't recognise it kept adjusting, kept correcting, eventually painted their way to something inert.

Leon recognised it.

She thought: he stopped at the right moment.

She thought: that is rarer than it sounds.

Vocabulary Support

completion	tamamlanma
indicator	gösterge
inert	cansız, durağan
adjusting	ayarlamak
keep correcting	düzeltmeye devam etmek
stepped back	geri çekildi

He stopped at the right moment. Rarer than it sounds. She knows.

Page 13 — What She Said to Him

After the final session, she said: 'Can I ask you something, as the subject rather than the tutor?'

'Yes,' he said.

'What did you find that you were not expecting to find?'

Leon thought for a longer time than she had expected.

He said: 'I expected to find someone who knew they were being painted and was managing it. I found that instead. But I also found something I wasn't looking for — that the managing was part of it. That the attempt to be present rather than perform was itself a kind of performance. And that when the attempt stopped, something appeared.'

'What appeared?' she asked.

'I'm not sure I can say it in words,' he said. 'It's in the painting.'

She looked at the painting.

'Yes,' she said. 'I think I can see it.'

Vocabulary Support

managing it	yönetmek
attempt to be present	mevcut olmaya çalışmak

itself a kind of performance	kendi içinde bir performans
when the attempt stopped	çaba durduğunda
appeared	ortaya çıktı
see it	görmek

"When the attempt stopped, something appeared." She can see it in the painting. What is it?

Page 14 — The Assessment

The final assessment panel had, as it was required to do, reached a collective view.

The work was given the highest available grade.

Frances had recused herself from the Leon's assessment on the grounds of the conflict of interest, which was the correct decision and which had been made easier by the fact that the other panel members had arrived at their view unanimously and did not require her vote.

The chair of the panel had asked her, over coffee after the assessment, what she thought.

'I think,' she said, 'that he has made a painting that does what painting can do and that a photograph cannot. That is, at this level, what we are looking for.'

The chair had nodded.

'And personally?' he had asked.

She had thought: how honest do I want to be? Then: entirely.

Vocabulary Support

recused herself	çekildi, kendini dışladı
conflict of interest	çıkar çatışması
unanimously	oybirliğiyle

panel	jüri
collectively	toplu olarak
highest available grade	mevcut en yüksek not

How honest do I want to be? Then: entirely. What did she say?

Page 15 — What She Said to the Chair

She had said: 'Personally, I found it unsettling in ways I had not anticipated and illuminating in ways I did not expect.'

'Unsettling how?' 'In the sense that it showed me something I do habitually and was not aware of doing. That is either what a portrait should do or what a portrait has no right to do. I'm genuinely not sure.'

'And illuminating?' 'In the sense that it confirmed something I have believed about portraiture for thirty years and had not, until I was the subject of it, fully experienced.'

'What's the belief?' She paused.

'That to be well painted is to be known. Not accurately. Not flatteringly. Known — with the particular weight that knowledge has when it is arrived at through prolonged attention rather than through information.'

The chair had looked at her for a moment.

'You should publish that,' he said.

'Leon said it first,' she said.

Vocabulary Support

unsettling	rahatsız edici
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illuminating	aydınlatıcı
flatteringly	yüceltici biçimde
prolonged attention	uzun süreli dikkat
arrived at through	... aracılığıyla ulaşılan
confirm	doğrulamak

"Leon said it first." She attributes the insight to him. Correctly.

Page 16 — The Portrait

Leon had offered to give her the portrait, which was not the convention — student final-year work was normally retained by the school.

She had declined.

She had said: 'It belongs in the collection. Students should be able to see it.'

She had also thought, and not said: I am not sure I want it in my house. I am not sure I want to live with what it knows.

The portrait was hung in the school's main corridor in the spring.

She passed it every day.

She had, over time, become comfortable with it — comfortable with what it showed her, comfortable with being known in the way it knew her.

Not every day. But most days.

Vocabulary Support

retained by	... tarafından tutulmak
collection	koleksiyon
convention	gelenek, kural
comfortable with	... ile rahat olmak
live with	... ile yaşamak
hung	asılmış

Not every day. But most days. Living with being known. That is what she learned.

Page 17 — What Changed

She had, in the year after the portrait was made, sat for two other portraits.

Not for students — for other professional painters, on commissions she had been offered.

She had found, in both cases, that the experience was measurably different from what it had been before Leon's project.

She was more patient. She was more willing to allow the silence to do its work. She was less tempted to manage the image she was projecting.

She had, she thought, learned something from being the subject that could only have been learned from being the subject.

She had already known it intellectually.

Leon had given her the experience.

Vocabulary Support

measurably different	ölçülebilir biçimde farklı
projecting	yansıtmak
intellectually	entelektüel olarak
measurably	ölçülebilir biçimde
professional painters	profesyonel ressamlar
commissions	siparişler, komisyonlar

She had known it intellectually. Leon gave her the experience. That is what students can do for teachers.

Page 18 — Leon

Leon graduated and had, in the two years since, established a practice that was — she tracked these things, as a teacher — developing as she had expected it to: steadily, seriously, with occasional work that was more than serious.

She had seen three of his subsequent portraits at group exhibitions.

All three had the quality she had identified in her own portrait — the quality of knowing rather than seeing, of showing the subject at a temporal remove.

He had also, she noticed, begun painting subjects who were not professional artists — a fisherman, a postman, a schoolteacher.

She thought: he is testing the question he asked in his thesis.

She thought: I hope he finds the answer, though I suspect it will complicate the question.

Vocabulary Support

established a practice	pratiğini kurdu
steadily	düzenli biçimde
subsequent portraits	sonraki portreleri
temporal remove	zamansal uzaklık
testing the question	soruyu sınamak

complicate	karmaşıktırtmak
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Testing the question from his thesis. She hopes he finds the answer. She suspects it will complicate things.

Page 19 — The Mirror

She had begun, in the second year after the portrait, to think differently about mirrors.

She had used mirrors as professional tools throughout her career — references for self-portraiture, checks on composition, tests of tonal relationships.

What she had not done, until Leon's project, was understand what a mirror was and was not.

A mirror was instantaneous — it showed you the present moment of your surface. A portrait was durational — it showed you the accumulated attention of a period of sustained looking.

The distinction was not between accurate and inaccurate. It was between surface and depth.

She thought: I have been painting depth for twenty-three years.

She thought: I have been using mirrors to check surfaces.

She thought: those are not the same looking.

Vocabulary Support

instantaneous	anlık
durational	süre içinde oluşan

tonal relationships	tonal ilişkiler
sustained looking	sürekli bakış
accumulated attention	birikmiş dikkat
self-portraiture	öz portre

Instantaneous vs durational. Surface vs depth. Not the same looking. She sees this now.

Page 20 — What the Mirror Knows

She had been asked to write a short essay for the school's magazine on the question of self-knowledge in art.

She had written, in part:

The mirror knows the surface of what you are at the moment you look. The portrait knows what the painter has understood about you over the duration of the work. Neither is more accurate. But they are not the same kind of knowing, and what they produce in the subject is not the same kind of information.

Being painted by a good painter is, I now believe, one of the few experiences in adult life that gives you access to the depth version of yourself rather than the surface version. Whether that access is always welcome is a different question.

In my case, it was not always welcome and was, in the end, entirely necessary.

She looked at the essay before submitting it.

She thought: Leon should see this.

She sent it to him.

Vocabulary Support

self-knowledge	öz bilgi
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duration of the work	işin süresi
depth version	derin sürüm
access to	... e erişim
welcome	hoş karşılanan
submitting	göndermek

*"Not always welcome and entirely necessary." She sends it to him.
The education ran in both directions.*

ACTIVITIES

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase	Meaning
1. portraitist	A. tutuluk
2. sitter	B. portre ressamı
3. recuse oneself	C. model, poz veren
4. consent	D. çekilmek, dışlamak
5. durational	E. süre içinde oluşan
6. instantaneous	F. anlık
7. temporal remove	G. zamansal uzaklık
8. conflict of interest	H. çıkar çatışması

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

known — managing — depth — ethics — consent — moment

1. Frances realised that to be well painted was to be _____, not seen.
2. Leon said he was waiting for the _____s when people forget they are being watched.
3. His thesis argued that _____ in portraiture was necessary but insufficient.

4. He concluded that the _____ of portraiture required ongoing negotiation, not a single agreement.
5. Frances used a mirror to check surfaces, but a portrait showed _____.
6. She said being painted by a good painter gave access to the _____ version of yourself.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Leon is a first-year student when he makes the request.

2. Frances finds sitting for a portrait easier than she expected. ___
3. Leon talks a great deal during the painting sessions. ___
4. Frances recuses herself from Leon's final assessment. ___
5. Frances keeps the portrait in her house. ___
6. Leon's thesis argues that consent alone resolves the ethics of portraiture. ___

Short Answer Questions

7. Why does Frances say yes to Leon's request?
8. What does Leon say he is looking for when he looks at Frances?
9. What does Frances notice about the painting at the mid-point that makes it feel unfamiliar?
10. How does Frances describe the power dynamic of the project?
11. What does Leon say he found that he was not expecting?
12. What does Frances mean when she says 'being known rather than seen'?
13. Why does Frances decline to keep the portrait?

14. What does the experience of being painted change in Frances when she subsequently sits for other portraits?
15. What distinction does Frances draw between a mirror and a portrait in her essay?

ANSWER KEY

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-C 3-D 4-A 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. known 2. moment 3. consent 4. ethics 5. depth 6. depth

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. F 6. F

7. She is curious about the experience of being painted, wants to see what an exceptional portraitist makes of her, and — the reason she didn't fully acknowledge at first — wants to know what she looks like to someone not managing her feelings about being sixty-one.

8. He is looking for the person who was thinking before they knew someone was watching — the moments when people forget they are being observed.

9. It shows a version of her she recognises but does not quite recognise — a considered version that the mirror does not show, one that incorporates temporal depth.

10. She had no adequate framework: she was both teacher and sitter, held more experience and knowledge, but he had more access to what she was in that moment than she did herself.

11. That the managing itself was part of the portrait material — the attempt to be present rather than perform was itself a kind of performance. When the attempt stopped, something appeared.

12. The mirror shows surface at the moment of looking; a portrait shows accumulated understanding over time — the subject is known with the weight that comes from prolonged attention, not just seen.

13. She said it belonged in the school collection for students to see — though she also thought, unspoken, that she was not sure she wanted to live with what it knows.

14. She became more patient, more willing to allow silence, less tempted to manage the image she was projecting — she had learned experientially what she had known intellectually.

15. A mirror is instantaneous — the present moment of your surface. A portrait is durational — accumulated attention over a period of sustained looking. Not the same kind of knowing, producing not the same kind of information.